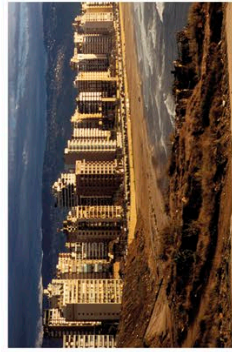




The Near East

ISRAEL, JORDAN, SYRIA, AND LEBANON are the countries collectively known as the Near East. This is a land that is dominated by desert but also has fertile coastal plains. Lack of water is a constant problem here, although Israel has introduced computerized irrigation systems to extend the land suitable for agriculture. The creation of the Jewish state of Israel in 1948, in what was previously Arab-dominated Palestine, has led to almost continuous conflict in the region. Lately, the devastating civil war in Syria has added more tension in the whole Near and Middle East region.

LEBANON REBUILT
Beirut, the capital of Lebanon, was once the commercial and banking center of the Arab world, but was devastated by the civil war that ravaged the country from 1975 to the early 1990s. Today, Beirut has regained some of its former glory. But Lebanon remains unstable, and is still dominated by its two powerful neighbors—Syria and Israel.



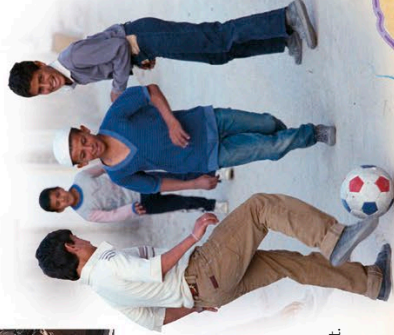
CYPRUS
Cyprus became independent from Britain in 1960. However, conflict between Greeks and Turks caused Turkey to invade the island in 1974. Since then, Cyprus has been split between a Turkish Cypriot north and a Greek Cypriot south. Most Cypriots make a living from farming grapes, citrus fruit, and olives, but tourism makes up a big part of the economy.

Woman making a lace-item to sell to tourists



SYRIAN MARKET
Damascus is one of the oldest inhabited cities in the world. At its center is a massive souk (bazaar), full of stalls and small shops selling everything from carpets, textiles, and jewelry to household goods and fresh produce.

The map on Cyprus's flag is copper-colored because "island means "island of copper."



DAILY LIFE
Even during war or conflicts, people try to continue to live as normally as possible, although it might be difficult to get food or go to school. These Palestinian boys enjoy a game of football in the street.

